



OpenPantry

Volunteer Handbook

FOR VOLUNTEERS

How to open and run the checkout and Menu Counter stations.

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START HERE

Welcome

Thank you for volunteering! OpenPantry is the software the pantry uses to check food out the door, keep the shelves counted, and know what to reorder. You don't need any technical background — this handbook walks you through opening each station and handling the few moments where the app asks you to do something.

You'll mostly work at one of two stations: the **Scanning Station** (grocery-style checkout with a barcode scanner) or the **Menu Counter** (a tablet where shoppers tap the items they want and volunteers pick the order in back). Both are covered below.

GOLDEN RULE

If anything looks wrong — a frozen screen, a scanner that won't beep, a weight that won't save — **don't force it**. Note the order number if there is one and ask the administrator on duty. Nothing you tap here can break the data. **One exception:** if a red **Recalled Product** window fills the screen and an alarm sounds, don't wait for anyone — take that item out of the cart first, then carry on. See “When an item has been recalled.” And if a **Connection lost** window covers the screen with three falling notes, stop scanning and wait — see “When the connection drops.”

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Getting on the stations

You do **not** need a password to run the scanning station or the Menu Counter. Those screens are locked to the pantry's own network address (its IP), so simply being on the pantry Wi-Fi is what authorizes them — they open straight to the work screen.

- The stations only work while you're on the **pantry's Wi-Fi**. On any other network the app shows an “Access Denied” screen — that's expected, not a login you're missing.
- OpenPantry may also be set to open only during pantry hours. Outside those hours you'll see “Access is closed right now.” Try again during service.
- If the pantry's internet address changes, the stations show that same “Access Denied” screen even on the right Wi-Fi. Whoever holds the **supervisor password** can put it right: open **Settings**, and under Secure Network Access press **Use My Current IP** and then **Set IP Address**. That is the one setting a supervisor can change — the rest of the page is read-only for them, so there is nothing to break.
- If the address changes *while* the Scan page is already open, you won't see the Access Denied screen. Instead a **The server refused this station** window comes up and says why — the network address, or the pantry's hours. It clears itself as soon as the address is fixed or the hours open; see “When the connection drops.”
- A password is only requested on **administrator** screens — item setup, Settings, reports, and the delivery client list. Volunteers don't use those day to day; if you land on one by mistake, back out and ask the administrator.

Open-the-Station Checklist — Scanning Station

Work top to bottom. Tick each box as you go.

☐

Power on the Chromebook tablet and connect it to the pantry Wi-Fi (the station only works on the pantry network) if it is not already connected.

☐

Make sure the handheld barcode scanner is connected to the tablet; wait for its ready beep / steady LED.

☐

Power on the produce scale and confirm the scale strip reads **Scale ready**; see the setup below if it does not.

☐

Open the browser and go to the OpenPantry **Scan** page. It opens straight to the scanner — **no password** is needed, because the pantry network authorizes the station.

☐

Scan any item's barcode as a test — a “Last scan” line should appear. Then tap the red ✕ **Cancel Order** so the test doesn't count.

☐

Tap once inside the barcode box so the cursor sits there (it glows green when focused).

NO WIRED SCANNER? USE THE CAMERA ON THE SAME PAGE

There is one **Scan** page for both ways of scanning. On a phone or any tablet without a handheld scanner, tap **Start Camera** in the *This Order* box and point the camera at the barcode — the page chirps once for each code it reads. **Stop Camera** puts it away. The camera needs permission the first time, and the page must be opened over **https**.

CHECKOUT · THE PRODUCE SCALE

Setting up the produce scale (once per tablet)

The **DYMO M25** is a USB scale. It plugs into the tablet and sends its readings to OpenPantry on its own — there is no keypad sequence to enter, no mode to select, and no unit to set, because the station converts whatever unit the scale displays into pounds. All it needs is power and, the first time on a given tablet, the browser's permission:

1	Stand the scale on a flat, dry surface with nothing on the platform.	Nothing on the platform
2	Plug its USB cable into the tablet.	Connected to the station
3	Press the scale's power key and let the display settle to 0 .	Zero / stable reading
4	On the Scan page, read the scale strip just above the barcode box.	Says what the scale is doing
5	If it says Scale not connected , tap  Connect Scale and pick the scale from the browser's list.	Once per tablet only
6	Confirm the strip reads  Scale ready .	Interfaced to OpenPantry

WHEN THE STRIP SAYS “SCALE READY”, YOU'RE SET

That line means the station is hearing the scale. You can then weigh produce in **either order** — scan the PLU and set the item on the scale, or weigh it first and scan the PLU when the station asks for it. You only ever tap **Connect Scale** once on a tablet: the browser remembers the scale and reconnects by itself every later shift.

THE SCALE SWITCHES ITSELF OFF

The M25 powers down after a quiet spell to save its batteries, and a scale that has shut off looks exactly like one nobody has touched. If the strip says  **Make sure scale is on.**, press the scale's power key to wake it — you do *not* have to redo the steps above. If the display is awake but not reading **0** with an empty platform, press its **Tare / Zero** key.

CHECKOUT, STEP BY STEP

Running the Scanning Station

Starting and ending an order

- 1 You don't press "start" — the first item you scan automatically opens a new order and assigns it a number (shown large at the top).
- 2 Scan every item the shopper is taking — or add it by name if it won't scan (see below). Each entry drops into the list with a beep.
- 3 When they're done, tap ■ **End Order**. The counts are subtracted from inventory. (You can also scan the special End Order command barcode if your station has one posted.)
- 4 Made a mistake? Tap the red ✕ next to a line to remove that scan, or tap ✕ **Cancel Order** to throw the whole order away.

IF END OR CANCEL REFUSES

Very occasionally a pop-up says the order could not be ended or cancelled. **Read which one it is.** If it says the database was **busy**, another station was writing at that moment — just tap **End Order** again and it will go through. If it says **trying again will not help**, stop tapping and fetch the administrator. Either way **nothing was changed**: the order is still open with every scan on it, exactly as it was. A close that fails leaves no mess behind.

Adding an item by name (no barcode needed)

No barcode, a barcode that won't scan, or loose produce with no sticker? You can add the item by typing its **name** instead. The entry box is labeled **Barcode or Item Name** — start typing and, after two letters, matching items from the catalog appear beneath it as you type. When your text matches a single item, press **Enter** (or Tab) to record it, exactly as if you'd scanned it — or just tap it in the list. The best match is always first and printed twice as large, so it is an easy target on a touch screen. Digits on their own are still treated as a barcode, so typing a name never interferes with the scanner.

FASTEST FIX FOR A TORN OR MISSING BARCODE

If a label is smudged or peeled off, don't hunt for the number — just type the first few letters of the item's name and pick it from the list.

What you don't need to scan

You don't have to capture everything a shopper takes. The scan data drives reordering of the core, regularly-stocked staples, so a few categories can be safely ignored:

- High-calorie items with low nutritional value — e.g. candy, sweets, or desserts.
- Packaged meals and sandwiches.
- Anything that doesn't appear to be regularly stocked — one-off donations and oddments.

If you're unsure whether something is a regularly-stocked staple, ask the administrator.

PRODUCE SOLD BY WEIGHT

Weighing produce — either order

Fruits and vegetables are often sold by weight rather than count, so a produce entry has two halves: the **PLU code** on the sticker and the **weight** from the scale. The station takes them in **either order** — do whichever is quicker with your hands full, and don't tell the app which you're doing. It works it out.

Scan the PLU first

Scan the produce code. A **Weight required** window pops up and the station beeps:

- **Using the scale:** just set the item on the scale. If it's in “PC” mode (see the checklist) the weight fills in by itself — confirm and it saves.
- **By hand:** type 1 digit for pounds, then 2 digits for ounces. Example: typing **514** means **5 lb 14 oz**. Backspace fixes a slip; press **Enter** or **Save Weight**.

Or weigh it first

Set the item on the scale and leave it alone. The scale sends nothing until the reading settles, and then it sends it on its own — you don't press anything. The station catches the weight, beeps, and opens a **Weighed — PLU required** window with the weight shown at the top. (On an older cable-connected scale this half needs it in “PC” mode — in **print** mode it only sends when you press **PRINT**. A USB scale needs no setting at all.)

- 1 Scan the PLU sticker (or type the code and press **Enter**). The weight you already took and the code are saved together as one line.
- 2 Don't know the code? Tap **Type a name instead** and start typing the produce name — only items sold by the pound are offered, so you can't accidentally pick something that would throw the weight away. Pick a match and its PLU is filled in for you.
- 3 Wrong item on the scale, or you'd rather start over? **Discard Weight** throws the reading away and nothing is recorded.

CLEAR THE PLATFORM AFTER EVERY ITEM

Whichever order you use, take the item off the scale and let it return to **0** before the next one. The scale only arms itself to send again once it has been cleared — a platform left loaded is the usual reason a weight “doesn't come through.” You don't have to watch the screen for it. On a USB scale the station plays a **short soft tick** the moment the platform is clear and the last item's code is in, and that tick is your cue to set the next item down. It sounds once per item, and it is quieter and rounder than every other sound here so it won't be mistaken for one — work to it and you will never put an item on too early.

IF SOMETHING LOOKS OFF WITH A WEIGHT

The station protects you from the two mistakes that matter. If a cable-connected scale is set to **kilograms** (or grams or ounces) it **refuses** the reading and asks you to switch it to **lb**, rather than recording a number that's less than half the real weight. (A USB scale needs no such warning — it reports its own units and the station converts them.) And if a scale sends the same weight twice for one item, the repeat is recognized and ignored — you won't get a duplicate line.

The scale strip

If your station uses a **USB scale**, a short strip sits just above the barcode box and tells you what the scale is doing. You never have to touch it during a normal shift — glance at it only when a weight doesn't arrive.

- 📊 **Scale connected — waiting for a reading...** — the station has found the scale but hasn't heard from it yet. Normal for a second or two after opening the page; if it stays, the scale isn't switched on.
- 📊 **Scale ready** — nothing on the platform, waiting for the next item.
- 📊 **Weighing...** — the reading is still moving. Take your hand off and let it settle.
- 📊 **Settling...** — the reading has stopped moving and the station is confirming it holds. Usually well under a second, and it is deliberate: scales call a weight “steady” a moment before it really is, so the station waits rather than banking a number that is still creeping up. A weight that is still drifting holds here longer — that pause is the station protecting the number, not lagging.
- 📊 **Total weight at ... lb.** — the weight is in. Scan the PLU, then clear the platform.
- ⚠️ **No PLU entered.** — you put another item on while the last weight was still waiting to be identified. See below.
- 📊 **Clear the platform to weigh the next item.** — something is still sitting on the scale from the item you just finished. Lift it off and the scale is ready again.
- ⚠️ **Put on too soon — lift the item off and set it down again.** — a new item landed on the platform before the scale had finished with the last one, so the moment the platform was clear went by unseen and **this item is not being weighed**. Nothing is wrong with the item or the scale, and waiting will not clear it: lift the item off, wait for the tick, and set it back down.
- ⚠️ **Make sure scale is on.** — see below.
- ⚠️ **Over capacity** — the item is too heavy for this scale. Take it off and weigh it in two batches.
- ⚠️ **Scale needs re-zeroing** — clear the platform and press the scale's own **Tare** or **Zero** key.
- ⚠️ **Scale is reporting an unrecognized unit** — the scale has been switched to a unit the station doesn't record in. Use its **Units** key to put it back to **lb** or **oz**.
- ⚠️ **Scale fault** — switch the scale off and on again. If it comes back, carry on; if not, tell the administrator.
- ⚠️ **Scale disconnected** — the USB cable came loose, or the scale lost power. Re-seat the cable.

ONE WEIGHT AT A TIME

Once the scale has taken a weight, the station holds it until you enter the PLU or press **Discard Weight** — and it will not weigh anything else in the meantime. Put a second item on by mistake and nothing happens: no beep, and the strip reads **No PLU entered**. The weight on screen is still the first item's, so finish that one and it records correctly. The mistaken item is **ignored completely** — it will not pop up asking for a PLU afterwards. To weigh it for real, take it off the scale and put it back on.

“MAKE SURE SCALE IS ON.”

Scales switch themselves off to save their batteries, and a scale that has gone to sleep looks exactly like one nobody has used. The station **beeps** and shows **Make sure scale is on**. in two cases: when it has heard nothing at all since you opened the page (about ten seconds in — the scale was never switched on), and when the weight hasn't changed for **three minutes** (it was on and has since gone to sleep). Switch it back on, or set something on the platform, and the message clears itself. Nothing is lost — it's a nudge, not an error, and it exists so you don't set produce on a dead scale and wonder why nothing happens.

PACKAGED GOODS

When the app doesn't recognize a barcode

Occasionally a packaged item isn't in the catalog. A box appears asking you to **Identify this item**. Type a short, plain generic name (e.g. "Canned Tuna", not the brand) and tap **Save & Record**. The app remembers it for next time. If you're unsure of the name, ask the administrator.

OR THE STATION MAY NAME IT "UNIDENTIFIED" AND MOVE ON

Your pantry may have the station set to keep the line moving rather than stop to ask. If so, an item it can't name **doesn't** open the Identify box at all: it swoops once, records the item under the placeholder name **Unidentified**, and shows a short note saying so. **That is a finished scan, not a failed one** — the item is counted, so bag it and carry on. Nothing is lost either: the name is only put off, and it can be filled in later.

You may meet the same thing from the other side. Scan an item and the Identify box sometimes opens already headed **Unidentified Item**, which means this barcode was recorded without a name on some earlier shift. Name it exactly as you would any other — and every past scan of *that one barcode* is renamed along with it, which is why it is worth doing whenever the box offers.

KEEP THE CURSOR IN THE BOX

The scanner types like a keyboard, so the barcode box must stay selected (it glows green). If scans stop registering, tap once inside that box and try again.

When an item has been recalled

A recall is the one moment at this station where you act first and ask afterwards. If a product has been recalled — a contamination, an undeclared allergen, a packaging fault — it must not leave the pantry, and the station is built so that you cannot miss it.

Scan a recalled item and everything stops. A **red window** fills the screen, pulsing, headed **Recalled Product**, and an alarm sounds: a two-tone siren about a second and a half long, deliberately longer and more insistent than any other sound the station makes, so it carries even if you are several feet away with your back to the screen. The window names the item, so you know which package in the cart it means.

- 1 **Take that item out of the cart now**, before anything else. Don't bag it, and don't hand it back to the shopper.
- 2 Put it somewhere it can't be picked up again by mistake — away from the cart and away from the shelves.
- 3 Tap **Item Removed** to close the window. The siren has already stopped on its own by then; that button is you confirming the package is out of the cart, which is why nothing else dismisses the window — not tapping the background, not pressing Escape. You land back in the barcode box and the rest of the order carries on as normal.
- 4 Tell the administrator on duty before you finish your shift. There are very likely more of them on the shelves.

IT WAS NOT RECORDED, AND SCANNING IT AGAIN WON'T HELP

Nothing about a recalled item goes onto the order — it isn't counted and it isn't taken out of inventory, so there is nothing for you to undo. The last-scan line says **not recorded** for exactly that reason. Scanning it a second time simply raises the same alarm again: the block isn't on your screen, it's on the server, so it holds on every station at once. Only an administrator can lift a recall, from the Lookup Tables page.

IF THE SHOPPER ASKS

You don't have to explain the recall, and please don't guess at the reason. “This one has been recalled, so I can't let it go out — let me find you another” is the whole of it. If they want to know more, fetch the administrator.

IF THE INTERNET GOES DOWN

When the connection drops

Every scan is saved on the pantry's server over the internet. If the station loses touch with the server, it stops you straight away rather than letting you scan items that quietly go nowhere.

You'll know at once. A red **Connection lost** window covers the screen, headed **Connection problem — stop scanning**, and the station plays **three long falling notes** — slower and lower than the recall siren, and nothing like the short buzz of a rejected item. Within a few seconds the window says which of three things has gone wrong:

- **No internet connection** — the problem is at the pantry: the Wi-Fi, a cable, or the router. Check the tablet is still on the pantry Wi-Fi and tell whoever looks after the router.
 - **The pantry server isn't responding** — the pantry's internet is fine; the website itself is down. Restarting the router won't help. If it lasts more than a few minutes, tell the administrator.
 - **The server refused this station** — the server is up but is turning this station away, because the pantry's network address has changed or scanning is outside the pantry's hours. A supervisor or administrator can fix the address in Settings (see “Getting on the stations”).
- 1 **Stop scanning.** There is nothing to press — the window has no buttons, because the only fix is the connection coming back.
 - 2 Anything scanned while the window is up is refused with a buzz and **not recorded**. The window lists those barcodes; set the items aside so you can scan them again.
 - 3 The station checks the connection every few seconds on its own. When it's back, the window lifts with **three rising notes** and a green notice says **Connection restored — you can scan again**. The **This Order** list is redrawn from the server, so it shows exactly what was saved.
 - 4 Read the green notice before you carry on. It stays up for 30 seconds when there is something on it.

“NOT RECORDED” AND “MAY NOT HAVE SAVED” ARE DIFFERENT

The notice can list items two ways, and they need opposite handling. **NOT recorded, scan again** means the item certainly didn't reach the server — scan it again. **Check This Order for ...** means the connection dropped while that item was being saved, so it may have landed. **Look for it in This Order first**, and scan it again only if it isn't there — scanning it blind could count it twice.

NOTHING ALREADY SAVED IS LOST

An outage never undoes scans that were saved before it. The order stays open on the server, with everything on it, and carries on once the connection returns. A weight, name, or recall window you hadn't finished when the line dropped is still there underneath when the window lifts — finish it then.

Helping on someone else's order (Assist)

On a busy day two volunteers can check the same household out together — one working the wired scanner, one with a phone camera on the other side of the cart. Both sets of scans land in the **same order**, so the shopper is counted once.

Joining an order

- 1 Open the **Scan** page on your device. If another station already has an order going, a card appears titled **Another station is scanning**, listing the order number, when it started, and how many items are on it so far.
- 2 Tap **+ Assist** on the order you're helping with. The top of your screen changes from *Current Order* to **Assisting Order #...**
- 3 Scan normally. Everything you scan goes onto the shared order, and each screen shows the other's items within a couple of seconds — no refreshing.
- 4 Keep scanning for the next household. When the other volunteer ends the order, your screen shows **Assist Mode — waiting for the next order to assist** and joins the next order they start on its own, so a pair can work straight through a line without re-joining between shoppers.
- 5 When you're done helping for good, tap **Leave Assist**. That is the only thing that takes your station out of assist mode and lets it start orders of its own again.
 - While your station is waiting between orders, scanning an item joins the next order and records it there — no need to wait for the screen to catch up. If nobody has started one yet, the scanner buzzes and says so, and nothing is recorded.
 - If your station has the **Assist** command barcode posted, scanning it does the same thing as tapping **+ Assist**, so you never have to touch the screen. It only works when exactly one other station has an order open — if two do, the barcode says so and you pick from the card.

Who ends the order

The station that **started** the order owns it. Only that screen has **End Order** and **Cancel Order**; a helper sees **Leave Assist** in their place. That's deliberate — it keeps two people from closing the same shopper out twice, and stops a helper cancelling an order that isn't theirs. If you're helping and the shopper is finished, tell the volunteer who started it.

- The starting station shows a “**1 assisting**” tag while you're helping, so they know you're on it.
- Once two stations share an order, a **Who** column appears in the item list. Your own scans carry a filled badge, your teammate's an outlined one. On a single station the column stays hidden.
- While you're assisting, your device beeps on each item you scan — useful on a phone, which has no scanner of its own to beep at you. The **Beep on each scan** switch next to **Leave Assist** turns it off if the room is already noisy enough. It starts on, and whichever way you leave it is how your device comes back the next time it assists.
- **Either** of you can remove a mis-scan with the red ✕ — including a line the other person entered.

YOU CAN'T ASSIST WITH YOUR OWN ORDER OPEN

If your station already has an order going, finish it first — the app will say *“End this station's own order before assisting another.”* The Assist card only appears on a station that is idle, and a pantry running a single scanner never sees it at all.

CUSTOMER ORDERING KIOSK

Open-the-Station Checklist — Menu Counter

The Menu Counter has two screens: the **customer order form** that shoppers tap, and the **pick queue** that volunteers pull from in the back.

Customer-facing tablet

- ☐ Power on the customer tablet and connect it to the pantry Wi-Fi.
- ☐ Open the browser to the OpenPantry **Menu Counter** order form. It opens directly — **no password** to enter.
- ☐ Confirm the page loads the item buttons grouped by category (Dairy, Dry Goods, Frozen, ...).
- ☐ Set the language selector back to English so the next shopper starts fresh.
- ☐ Stand the tablet in its holder facing the shopper; clean the screen.

Pick-queue tablet / screen (back of house)

- ☐ Open the **Menu Counter** → **Orders** (pick queue) page on the volunteer screen. It opens directly — **no password** needed.
- ☐ Confirm the queue auto-refreshes and the topbar shows “pending orders” and “items remaining”.
- ☐ Submit one test order from the customer tablet and confirm it appears in the queue, then Mark Complete to clear it.
- ☐ Make sure bags/bins and a pen are staged at the pick bench.

NO LOGIN ON THE PANTRY NETWORK

The Menu Counter order form and pick queue are secured by the pantry's network address, not a password, so volunteers never log in to use them. A password is only asked for on the administrator's **item-setup** screen — leave that to the person opening the pantry.

ORDERS & PICKING

Running the Menu Counter

Helping a shopper at the order form

- Shoppers tap the food items they want; selected items highlight. Items marked unavailable show but can't be picked.
- Besides entering their first name, they enter how many adults and children are in the household — the app uses that to set quantities automatically.
- Some items ask for a size (e.g. diapers) — a dropdown appears when the item is selected.

- A translate button lets shoppers switch languages; the form returns to English after each order so the next person starts fresh.
- When they submit, a confirmation appears and the order drops into the pick queue in back.

Picking an order in back

- 1 New orders appear in the queue sidebar with a progress bar. Tap one to open its list.
- 2 Gather each item and tap it to mark it picked (it turns green with a check).
- 3 Use + to add another of an item, or ✕ to remove one that's out of stock or entered accidentally.
- 4 Once every item is checked, tap **Mark Complete** to clear the order from the queue.
- 5 The queue refreshes on its own every 5 seconds — no need to reload. The dot beside **Refresh** pulses green while it does.

IF THE PICK QUEUE LOSES ITS CONNECTION

The pick queue watches its connection the same way the scanning station does. If it can't reach the server, the dot beside Refresh turns red, a **Connection problem — stop picking** window covers the screen with three falling notes, and it says whether it's the internet or the server. Stop ticking items — a tick made now would look saved and not be. When the connection returns the window lifts with three rising notes and the picklist **reloads from the server**, so every check mark shows what was really saved. The green notice lists any tick, +, ✕, or **Mark Complete** that was **NOT saved** (do it again) or that **may have saved** (look before you redo it).

DELIVERIES & EVENTS

Other channels you may see

Some volunteers help with home **Deliveries** or **Events** (community meals). These use their own simple forms reached from the top menu under **Checkout**. The pattern is the same: pick the items and counts, then submit. A volunteer lead will show you the delivery rotation and printing steps — and remember that client names, addresses, and phone numbers are private (see below).

EVERY SHIFT

Privacy & closing up

Protecting shopper privacy

- Never share or write down a shopper's name, address, or phone number outside the app.
- Don't leave a logged-in tablet unattended where the public can reach the reports.

Closing the station

☐

Finish or cancel any order still open on the scanning station (the top should read “not started”).

☐

If you were helping another station, tap **Leave Assist** — or make sure the volunteer who started the order has ended it.

☐

Take the last item off the produce scale so it reads **0**. If the scale strip says **Make sure scale is on.**, that's fine at closing — it just went to sleep.

☐

Clear any leftover orders from the Menu Counter pick queue.

☐

Log out (the **Log out** link, top right) if you're leaving the tablet in a public spot and the admin is signed into the app.

☐

There is no need to power off the equipment, but make sure the tablets are on their chargers.

☐

Tell the administrator about anything odd that happened during the shift.

THANK YOU

Every order you check out becomes data that helps the pantry order smarter and show donors the real need. Your careful scanning literally keeps the shelves stocked.